School of Science, Computing and Engineering Technologies

HONOURS PROJECT REPORT GUIDE



2025

To be read by both candidates and supervisors

PREFACE

If we knew what it was we were doing, it would not be called research, would it?

Albert Einstein

Honours is an intellectually rewarding and personally fulfilling experience. Intellectually, you will undertake study at a higher level than in your undergraduate degree both in your honours units and when you carry out research for your thesis, report or dissertation. The report allows you to focus on an area of particular interest and provides the opportunity to make contribution to knowledge and wider debates in your discipline.

On a personal basis, the skills acquired during this period will enhance your future career prospects in a broad range of occupations, in both the public and private sectors, giving you an edge compared with a straight undergraduate pass degree. While your bachelor's degree provides you with fundamental knowledge underpinning the scientific principles related to real-life applications, during your honours year you will have an opportunity to develop soft and transferable skills.

Research is about discovery, the proposal of new ideas and the assessment of new hypotheses. It is about the establishment of facts through enquiry and exploration, and its outcome is new knowledge, leading to deeper understanding of mechanisms and the development of new and improved procedures. To ensure that the use of research results is maximised, it must be disseminated in a suitable format.

The purpose of this guide, intended for students completing their Honours degree in Science at Swinburne University of Technology, is to outline the standard requirements a Honours Report should adhere to, as far as general format, layout and structure of the manuscript are concerned, in order to be accepted. The guide touches only tangentially on questions of literature review, methodology and content, as these are likely to be topic/stream specific, and will be limited to generic matters that are relevant across disciplines.

Acknowledgement of Contributors

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GENERAL REQUIREMENTS

This document is intended as a guide for Swinburne's students enrolled in a Bachelor of Science (Honours), Bachelor of Computer Science (Honours) and Bachelor of Health Science (Honours) undertaking the project unit NPS40013 Honours Project B. The guide may also be of use for student enrolled in NPS40012 Honours Project A in that it addresses matters pertinent to Format and Style, and does not elaborate on Content that is project specific.

Length of the Report

A single report is to be submitted for each unit and should be within the range given and not exceed the maximum word count.

NPS40012 Honours Project A: 4000- **5000** words
NPS40013 Honours Project B: 12,000 - **15000** words

The word count only includes the main text (see Appendix A)

The word count must be provide on the title page and the 15000 word limit must be identified (highlighted) in main text.

Language and Style

The report should be in a form suitable for submission for examination. All spelling, grammar, and punctuation must be thoroughly checked and the choice of language should be appropriate to a **high level of scholarly work**. This style should be apparent through your research in digesting peer-reviewed papers, student's honours and PhD thesis and scholarly articles. The list of references should be accurate and consistent, in a form appropriate to the discipline. Remember, your supervisor is the first point of contact for any questions related to your research. You should therefore discuss all aspects of your report with your supervisor(s) throughout your project.

Writing Skills Support

If you need assistance with academic literacy, issues such as the mechanics of your writing (for example, cohesion and coherence, structure and transitions, referencing and citation) you may consult the support services offered by the university. For more information about the Learning and Academic Skills (LAS) Centre, please visit:

http://www.swinburne.edu.au/student/study-help/las.html

Involvement of Supervisors

The group report should be your own, and your teammates, original work but you should consult your supervisor for advice on organization of the report, and to assess the logic and consistency of arguments you have used in interpretations and discussions. It is a good idea to have your academic supervisor read your final draft, allowing enough time, however, for the return of the draft with suggested amendments. Major editing or rewriting of the document must be completed by the group members only.

Student Declaration

When formally submitting the group report all group members must sign the Swinburne cover sheet for submission of work for assessment Plagiarism. This should be included as page two of the report.

https://www.swinburne.edu.au/media/swinburneeduau/current-students/docs/pdf/Cover_sheet_for_submission_of_work_for_assessment.pdf

Plagiarism is viewed very seriously. Ignorance is no excuse. You should familiarise yourself with the University policy on plagiarism, which can be found here:

http://www.swinburne.edu.au/student-administration/assessment/misconduct.html

General Format and Layout

Layout is, to a certain degree, a matter of personal taste. However, in the context of academic writing, there is not much room for the imagination. It is also important to take into account the typographic style of the University. Nonetheless, you can do much to improve the readability and appearance of your report by following a few simple rules.

REMEMBER: you are not writing this report for you, but for an examiner!

Some of the more important issues related to layout are:

- sizes of page margins and line spacings
- formats of
  - the title page
  - the contents list
  - appendices
  - the reference list
  - illustrations, figures and tables
- numbering systems for
  - chapters and sections
  - pages
  - figure and table captions
  - equations
- font-styles for
  - chapter and section headings
  - other text
  - figure and table captions
  - equations
  - quoted work
  - citations
- how references are cited
- how tables, figures and equations are cited

Font

A single font must be used throughout the report, the only exceptions being in tables, graphs, and appendices. Headings may be bolded and no more than 2 points larger than the rest of the text.

Margins

The margins on each sheet should be as follows: 40 mm Left, 20 mm Right, 30 mm Top, and 20 mm Bottom. Page numbers must be placed at least 20 mm from the bottom of the page.

Line Spacing

The whole report should be 1.5-spaced. Single spacing may be used only in Table of Contents, footnotes and endnotes, charts, graphs, tables, quotations, captions, glossary, appendices, and bibliography

Headers and Footers

Headers and footers can be used to provide information to the reader, such as the page number, the title of the publication or current chapter or section. The general recommendation is Page Number centred in the FOOTER, leaving the header for chapter number.

Tips

- Seek the advice of your research supervisor.
- Write the Abstract and Introduction chapter last - once you have written the other main chapters, it is easier to summarise the work done, and to give an overview of the dissertation.
- Think about the objectives of the project; what was done and the results that were obtained.
- Divide the contents into the appropriate chapters and sections; this will help rationalise the contents.
- The repeated use of words can make a report difficult, if not boring, to read. Use a thesaurus or a dictionary to get synonyms to introduce variety, but make sure that they are used in the proper context.
  http://dictionary.cambridge.org/
- Be meticulous about the final chapter.
- Try to get a copy of a thesis or dissertation written by a student in your department/research group to gain a visual feel for how the dissertation is organised, formatting conventions, and to get an idea of what material should be placed in which chapters.
- Consult online theses databases, e.g.
  http://www.swinburne.edu.au/lib/subjectguide/theses.htm

ORGANISATION OF THE MANUSCRIPT

All reports have an abstract, introduction, main chapters and conclusion. The number and content of the main chapters vary depending on the discipline and your approach to the topic. Other sections include acknowledgements, appendices, lists of tables and figures, and references. The following structure is most commonly used in the sciences.

Front Sections	The Main Text	End Sections
▪ Title page ▪ Declaration ▪ Abstract ▪ Dedication (optional) ▪ Acknowledgements (optional) ▪ Table of Contents ▪ List of tables* ▪ List of figures* ▪ List of illustrations/schemes* ▪ List of abbreviations* ▪ List of symbols*	▪ Chapters	▪ References ▪ Appendices*

** if applicable*

The main text is generally organised in the IMRaD format, the most prominent norm for the structuring of scientific articles; IMRaD is an acronym for *Introduction – Method – Results – and – Discussion*. See Appendix A for an example structure. Your groups manuscript tells the story of your teams research, and, as illustrated in the table below, should ideally answer the identified questions to generate a continuous flow.

Questions to answer	Component of Report
What is the research about?	Introduction/Rationale
What is already known?	Literature review
What needs to be found? (Gap analysis)	Aims/hypothesis
How do I go about my research?	Methodology
What did I find?	Results
What do the results mean?	Discussion
So what? What is the significance and what are the contributions?	Conclusion
What should happen now?	Future works

The sequence presented is only a recommended one; it does not represent a prescribed template. There are many variations to research theses, and it is imperative that you read other theses from your discipline, to acquaint yourself with the appropriate style.

Responsibility for the final format of the report rests with the students after consultation with their supervisor(s). **You must discuss** the structure of your manuscript with your supervisor before you start planning your writing.

Title Page

The title page should contain (**prescriptive**):

- Swinburne Landscape Logo, top of the page
- Full title of the research project (Small Caps and Bold)
- The authors names
- Word count

See Appendix B for a Sample Title Page. Everything appearing on the title page must be centred, both vertically and horizontally.

Declaration

https://www.swinburne.edu.au/media/swinburneeduau/current-students/docs/pdf/Cover_sheet_for_submission_of_work_for_assessment.pdf

Abstract

An abstract is a concise summary of a research paper or entire report/thesis. It is an original work, not an excerpted passage. An abstract must be fully self-contained and make sense by itself, without further reference to outside sources or to the actual paper. It highlights key content areas, the research purpose, the relevance or importance of the work, and the main outcomes. The recommended length for the project report is: **300-350 words**.

The abstract should address the following questions in a continuous flow, with the following suggested structure:

Reason
What is the importance of the research? Why would a reader be interested in the larger work?

Problem
What problem does this work attempt to solve? What is the scope of the project? What is the main argument, thesis or claim?

Methodology
An abstract of a scientific work may include specific models or approaches used in the larger study. Other abstracts may describe the types of evidence used in the research.

Results
An abstract of a scientific work may include specific data that indicates the results of the project. Other abstracts may discuss the findings in a more general way.

Implications
How does this work add to the body of knowledge on the topic? Are there any practical or theoretical applications from your findings or implications for future research?

The importance given to the different components can vary between disciplines, and it is advised that you look at abstracts that are similar to your own works as models.

(This list of elements is adapted from: http://writingcenter.unc.edu/handouts/abstracts)

Dedication (optional)

If you wish to dedicate your work to one or more people, this tribute may be made on a separate page, following the abstract. The dedication page (if included) is the first page to receive a page number and is identified as “ii.”

Acknowledgements (optional)

This page is for the author to express professional and/or personal indebtedness. Permission(s) to use previously copyrighted materials, receipt of grant funds, recognition of “readers”, etc. is acknowledged on this page. Students must be consistent with the use of the third ("the author") or first person throughout.

Table of Contents

The Table of Contents is a topic outline of the manuscript. It functions as an index to the work, and must fully and accurately reflects the organisation of the manuscript. It is highly recommended that students using the “Automatic Table of Contents” feature in Microsoft Word wait until all final edits to all parts of the manuscript are complete. All chapter divisions and subsections must be included in TOC and labeled exactly as they appear in the text.

List of Tables, Figures, Illustrations/Schemes, Abbreviations, Symbols

The list of tables provides the table numbers, captions and page numbers for all tables, including those in the appendices. The list of figures provides the numbers, legends and page numbers of all figures. List captions and legends exactly as they are found in the text. If you wish to include a list of symbols or a list of abbreviations, place it after the list of figures. The terms included in this list must be defined when they are first mentioned in the main body of the manuscript.

The Main Body of Text

See Section 3 on page 5.

List of References

Candidates should be familiar with the scholarly conventions in the presentation of references, accuracy of quotation, and construction of reference lists applicable to their discipline. The style and form of referencing to be used is agreed in consultation with the supervisors and it is essential that candidates be absolutely consistent in their use of a single method throughout their report. In the absence of an accepted style for the discipline, it is recommended that students use the Swinburne Harvard style.

http://www.swinburne.edu.au/lib/studyhelp/harvard_style.html

Another popular style in STEM is APA, from the American Phycological Association. Here is a quick reference guide for using this style.

Appendix or Appendices

This section presents supplementary material such as original data or other materials that are helpful but not essential. In case of more than one appendix, give each one a descriptive title.

SUGGESTIONS FOR THE MAIN TEXT

Since the Report is usually rather lengthy, a uniform organisational scheme should be applied to the whole text so that a reader can tell at a glance what is of greater importance. Breaking the text into too many small parts should be avoided.

The text may be divided into chapters, parts, or other types of sections, and the principles of division must be consistent throughout. Two popular arrangement schemes are the headings system and the decimal system. **It is recommended that you use the decimal system of headings with no more than three numbered levels**; an additional fourth level differentiated by an italic font is also acceptable.

1 Chapter
1.1 Section
1.1.1 Subsection

Introduction: Purpose and Significance of the Study

In the first chapter, clearly state what the purpose of the study is and explain the study's significance. The significance is addressed by discussing how the study adds to the theoretical body of knowledge in the field and the study's practical significance for global scientific community in the field being examined.

It is especially critical that this chapter be well developed, with a clearly defined purpose and strong theoretical grounding.

Review of the Literature

The purpose of the study should suggest some theoretical framework to be explained further in this chapter. The literature review thus describes and analyses previous research on the topic. In terms on of number word count and weighting, this part should not be more than **20-25%** of the whole report.

This chapter, however, should not merely string together what other researchers have found. Rather, you should discuss and analyse the body of knowledge with the ultimate goal of determining what is known and is not known about the topic. This determination leads to your research questions and/or hypotheses. In some cases, of course, you may determine that replicating previous research is needed. See Appendix for a checklist of important points. See Appendix D for some tips.

Methodology

This is often the easiest part of the report to write. It outlines which methods were chosen and why, i.e. the methodology: what, when, where, how and why you did what you did to get your results.

Results

Outlines what you found out in relation to your research questions or hypotheses, presented in figures (graphs), tables, and in written text. May be spread over more than one chapter.

Results contain the facts of your research. Often you will include a brief comment on the significance of key results, with the expectation that more generalised comments about results will be made in the Discussion section. Sometimes Results and Discussion are combined: check with your supervisor and with highly rated past theses in the Department.

Discussion

The Discussion section:

- comments on your results;
- explains what your results mean;
- interprets your results in a wider context; indicates which results were expected or unexpected;
- provides explanations for unexpected results.

The Discussion should also relate your specific results to previous research or theory. You should point out what the limitations were of your study, and note any questions that remain unanswered. The Discussion can also include Conclusions/Future Research. Check with your supervisor.

Conclusions

This is where you emphasise that your research aims/objectives have been achieved. You also emphasise the most significant results, note the limitations and make suggestions for further research. Conclusions can include Future Directions. Check with your supervisor.

What should be in the conclusion?

Conclusions: concise statements about your main findings, related to your aims/objectives/hypothesis.

Contributions to your field of research, stating/restating the significance of what you have discovered. Can include limitations.

Future research: where to go from here (can include where NOT to go, if your research demonstrated that a particular approach or avenue was not useful).

What should NOT be in the conclusion?

Discussion. This should be in the Discussion section. If your manuscript combines the two, use sub-headings to distinguish between them.

Any points that have not been mentioned in the Discussion section: your conclusions should be based only on points already raised.

References: it is quite unusual to include references in this section, as it is mainly a review of what has already been said.

Unnecessary information: your conclusion should be concise.

What am I trying to say in my conclusion?

What you are trying to say is:

- To what extent you achieved your aims/objectives OR not: if not, why?
- How important and significant your results are, as well as any limitations of your research (e.g. small sample size; other variables).
- Where the research should go from here: what are some interesting further areas to be explored based on what you have discovered or proven?

HOW TO MEET ASSESSMENT CRITERIA

When writing your report, think of what examiners will look for. Here are some useful questions for you to consider. Your aim is to be able to answer positively to all the questions. See Appendix E for the Examiners' Marking Scheme.

Report

Scope, originality, strength and clarity of argument, documentation, and research skills demonstrated.

General

- Is the topic clearly defined? Does the title reflect the topic?
- Is the choice of topic appropriate?
- Is the topic adequately justified in terms of the field?
- Is its scope clearly defined in terms of the corpus of texts, the range of documents or the range of data to be scrutinised?
- Are primary/secondary sources adequately used and referenced in the bibliography?
- Are the relevant key terms clearly defined?

Quality of argument, methodology, organisation of the report

The following are what examiners think of as "positive" criteria.

- Is the argument well developed?
- Is compelling and relevant evidence used to support the argument?
- Is the evidence introduced at the most helpful points of the argument? Does it prove what it purports to prove?
- Is the informing theory, methodology or theoretical framework well identified and explained?
- Does the report demonstrate knowledge of previous literature or intellectual endeavour in the field?
- Does the report demonstrate critical analysis of the material it works with?
- Is the report well structured? Is the division into chapters and/or sections rational and helpful? Are the chapters/sections optimally ordered?
- Does the introduction orient the work for the reader, and the conclusion account adequately for the work undertaken and the results achieved?
- Does the conclusion open up a direction for further research?

Language: Fluency, accuracy, and appropriateness

- Is the report readable (concise, accurate), and clear in meaning?
- Is its standard of language appropriate?
- Are language structures correct, grammatical and spelling rules respected?

Presentation

Relates to: layout, respect of bibliographical conventions, typographical accuracy etc.

- Does the report have a clear and detailed table of contents?
- Is the presentation of the report appropriate (margins, spaces, font, etc.)?
- Is the report well written in terms of spelling and typographical errors, punctuation?
- Is the style of footnoting consistent?
- Is every source quoted in the text and footnotes also listed in the bibliography?
- Is the bibliographic list consistent?
- Are websites and other sources listed systematically?

What makes a high distinction report

Work that meets this criteria detailed in Section 4.1 can expect to do very well. However, the **very top work** is distinguished by some special qualities. In order to award a High Distinction (80% and above), examiners will most likely ask the following questions:

- What qualities of **originality** does the report display?
- Does the manuscript evidence a **thorough** understanding of the underpinning theories?
- Is the experimental design **innovative**?
- Does the manuscript demonstrate **substantial** intellectual input?
- Could parts of the manuscript be submitted for **publication** in a scholarly?
- Has the group demonstrated a capacity to undertake further research study in **Honours**?

Attention!

Ask yourself the following questions, if you answer "yes" to them, it means the quality of your work needs improving.

- Is the existing secondary literature relied on or accepted too uncritically?
- Are the sources one-sided?
- Is the report limited to mere description and basic analysis of the data or principal texts?
- Does the conclusion merely restate the aims of the research?

Please remember to consult the University Plagiarism Policy

http://www.swinburne.edu.au/student-administration/assessment/misconduct.html

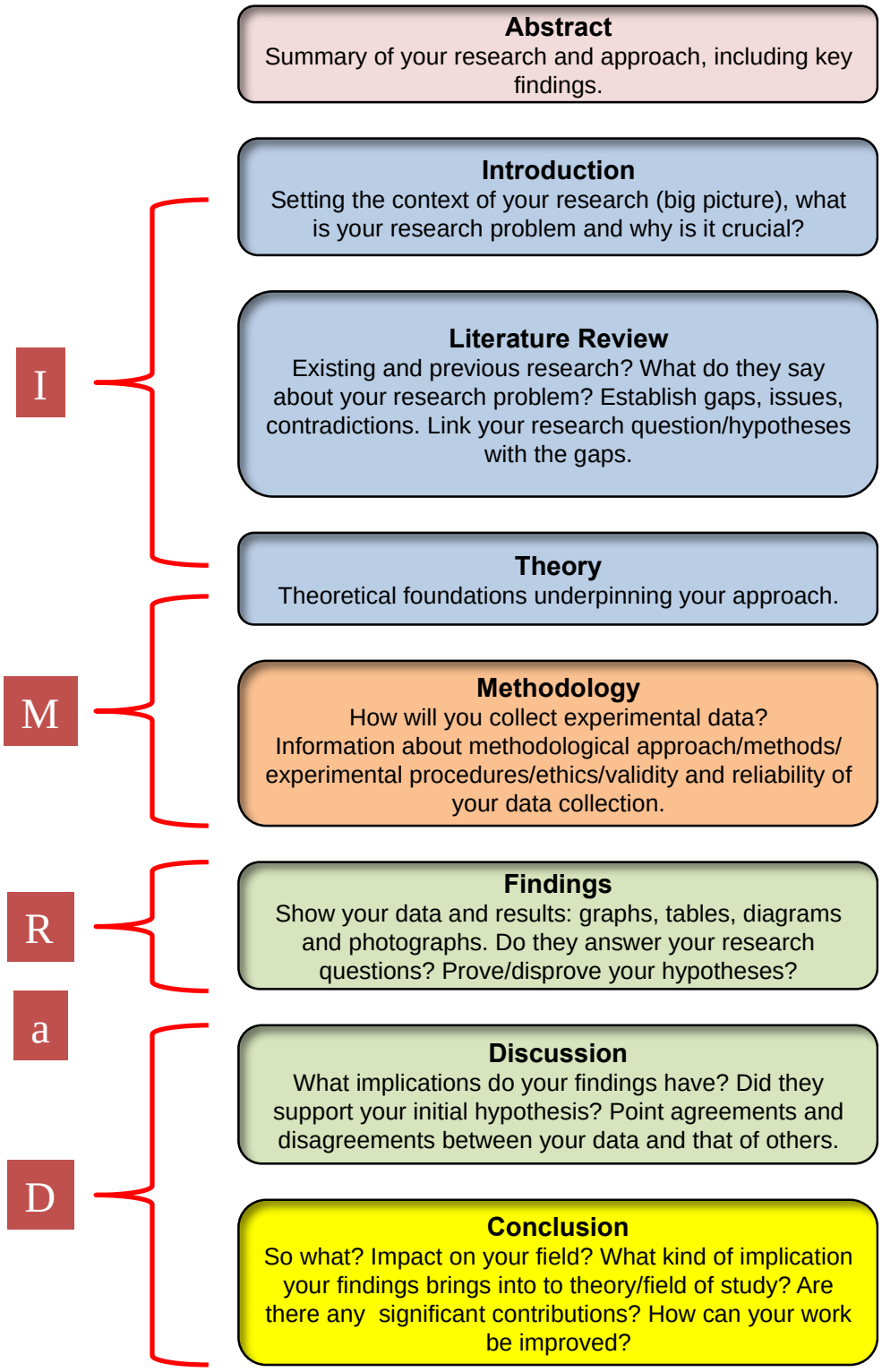
Submission of Copies of the Report

You are required to submit an electronic copy of the report for assessment as a PDF file through the Canvas Assignment system. See Appendix F for an Editing/Proofreading checklist.

GOOD LUCK!

APPENDIX A: THE IMRAD STRUCTURE

Main Text = Introduction – Method – Results – and – Discussion



APPENDIX B: SAMPLE TITLE PAGE



CELESTIAL ALLOYS AND THE ENIGMATIC VALYRIAN STEEL: UNLOCKING THE SECRETS OF AN OTHERWORLDLY METAL

NPS40013 HONOURS PROJECT B REPORT

by

Arya Stark

Word count = 14999

APPENDIX C: TIPS FOR LITERATURE REVIEW

Developing your Position

You need a rough statement of what you intend to accept or defend before you write your literature review, and preferably before you conduct extensive reading. As you read, you will need to refine and change this statement.

In helping to decide whether the literature you are reading is useful to you or not, consider the following method. First, write your proposed research statement on the top of a piece of paper, then divide the page into six columns headed as follows:

YES	Yes, but	Yes, BUT	No, but	No, BUT	NO

- "YES" indicates that the writer completely agrees with your proposed research statement.
- "Yes, but" indicates that they mainly agree with the statement but have minor disagreements.
- "Yes, BUT", indicates that the writer mainly agrees with the position you wish to defend; however they have some major disagreements.

Here is a checklist for the Literature Review, courtesy of the University of Melbourne:
http://library.unimelb.edu.au/libraries/bee/helpsheets

Selection of Sources

- Have you indicated the purpose of the review?
- Are the parameters of the review reasonable?
- Why did you include some of the literature and exclude others?
- Have you emphasised recent developments? Which years did you exclude??
- Have you focussed on primary sources with only selective use of secondary sources?
- Is the literature you have selected relevant?
- Is your bibliographic data complete?

Critical Evaluation of the Literature

- Have you organised your material according to issues?
- Is there a logic to the way you organised the material?
- Does the amount of detail included on an issue relate to its importance?
- Have you been sufficiently critical of design and methodological issues?
- Have you indicated when results were conflicting or inconclusive and discussed possible reasons?
- Have you indicated the relevance of each reference to your research?

Interpretation

- Has your summary of the current literature contributed to the reader's understanding of the problems?
- Does the design of your research reflect the methodological implications of the literature review?

Note

- The literature review will be judged in the context of your completed research.
- The review needs to further the reader's understanding of the problem and whether it provides a rationale for your research.

APPENDIX D: EDITING/PROOFREADING CHECKLIST

Use this checklist to help you produce a manuscript of high editorial standard.

Content

- ❒ Have I addressed all elements of the task?
- ❒ Have I demonstrated sufficient understanding of the topic and issue?
- ❒ Have I used a sufficient range of sources?
- ❒ Have I referred to ideas from other sources critically?
- ❒ Is my central argument clear?
- ❒ Are my supporting points clear?
- ❒ Is sufficient evidence provided?

Grammar

Have I checked for grammatical errors? These may involve:

- ❒ verb tenses
- ❒ subject-verb agreement
- ❒ plurals
- ❒ articles
- ❒ prepositions
- ❒ pronouns
- ❒ word forms

Sentence structure

- ❒ Are most sentences in the active voice?
- ❒ Do most sentences begin with the subject?
- ❒ Are sentences short and clear enough?
- ❒ Does sufficient sentence variety exist?

Vocabulary

- ❒ Is my vocabulary clear, accurate and formal?
- ❒ Do I refer to subjects themselves instead of overusing pronouns such as ‘it’, ‘they’ or ‘them’?
- ❒ Do I explain all technical terms and abbreviations when first used?
- ❒ Do I avoid overuse of abbreviations?

Expression

Is my writing as clear and concise as possible? Does it avoid:

- ❒ redundancies, (e.g. ‘absolutely perfect’, ‘completely surrounded’, ‘serious crisis’)
- ❒ tautologies (e.g. ‘A comparative study covering both aspects’)
- ❒ empty expressions or “waffle” (e.g. ‘in terms of’, ‘reflected in’, ‘in regards to’)
- ❒ vague words (‘factor’, ‘some’, ‘significant’, ‘aspect’)
- ❒ empty modifiers (e.g. ‘huge’, ‘very’)
- ❒ slang, colloquialism and informal terms

Presentation

Have I checked the presentation? This will include:

- ❒ font size and type
- ❒ indentation
- ❒ justification of paragraphs
- ❒ margins
- ❒ spacing
- ❒ section and page numbering
- ❒ headers and footers
- ❒ capitalisation
- ❒ italicised, bold-printed or underlined words (don’t overuse)
- ❒ wording and fonts of titles

Paragraphs

- ❒ Are paragraphs sequenced logically?
- ❒ Does each paragraph contain a topic sentence?
- ❒ Do all following sentences in the paragraph support the topic sentence?
- ❒ Does each paragraph contain only one main idea?
- ❒ Are linking words used? (e.g. ‘given this point...’, ‘first...’, ‘second...’, ‘in conclusion...’)
- ❒ Are paragraphs of appropriate length?
- ❒ Are titles used where necessary?

Tables, graphs and illustrations

Tables, graphs and illustrations are:

- ❒ positioned properly?
- ❒ referred to directly?
- ❒ titled and labelled correctly?
- ❒ cited appropriately?
- ❒ listed in the List of Tables or Illustrations?

Referencing and citations

- ❒ Are all sources acknowledged?
- ❒ Are citations formatted correctly?
- ❒ Are ideas from other sources paraphrased or summarised adequately?
- ❒ Are my positions on ideas from other sources clear?
- ❒ Are quotation marks used for direct quotes?
- ❒ Is the reference list complete and accurate?
- ❒ Is referencing consistent?